

The Dawn Newspaper

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Important Key Points Of Dawn Editorial

Editorial(1) Madressahs Politics:

Facts:

1. Bill Details:

- The Societies Registration (Amendment) Act, 2024, aimed at reforming madressah registration, was passed by parliament but not signed by the president due to “technical flaws.”
- The bill was spearheaded by the Jamiat Ulema-e-Islam (F) [JUI-F], led by Maulana Fazlur Rehman.

2. Accusations:

- Maulana Fazlur Rehman accused the government of backtracking on its promise to pass the bill in exchange for JUI-F’s support for the 26th Amendment.

3. Opposition to the Bill:

- The Council of Islamic Ideology (CII) and other clerics expressed reservations.
- The PML-N and PPP supported the 26th Amendment but are now hesitant to back the madressah law.
- The government has raised concerns about “legal complications” in the bill.

4. Madressah Oversight:

- The bill proposes to eliminate the Directorate General of Religious Education, transferring oversight to deputy commissioners.

5. Madressah Landscape:

- There has been a significant increase in the number of unregistered madressahs since the Afghan jihad, raising concerns about extremist and sectarian influences.

Issues:

1. Political Tactics:

- The PML-N and PPP may have supported the bill temporarily for political gain (to pass the 26th Amendment) and are now reluctant to follow through.

2. Resistance to Oversight:

- Clerical factions, including JUI-F, resist state regulation, emphasizing the ‘autonomy’ of madressahs.

3. Unregistered Madressahs:

- Thousands of madressahs remain unregistered, raising concerns about accountability, financing, and potential extremist teachings.

Recommendations:

1. Consensus Building:

- The issue should be resolved amicably among political stakeholders (ruling coalition, JUI-F) and clerics to avoid political and sectarian disputes.

2. Madressah Registration:

- All madressahs should be registered with provincial education departments.
- The curriculum should exclude hate and prejudice, and include life skills to prepare students for the economy.

3. Financial Transparency:

- Funds received by madressahs should be audited transparently.

4. Move Forward, Not Backwards:

- Returning oversight to deputy commissioners is seen as regressive; oversight should remain with relevant educational authorities to ensure reform progresses.

5. Standardization:

- Common standards of education and oversight must be enforced across all religious schools to balance autonomy with accountability.

Editorial(2) Targeting Travellers:

1. FBR's Proposed Regulations

New Baggage Rules:

- Goods deemed ‘for trading purposes’ and valued over \$1,200 were to be seized by customs authorities.
- Seized goods would not be released even if duties, taxes, and fines were paid.
- Travellers would be restricted to bringing in only two phones:
- One for personal use.

- The second allowed only upon payment of duties and fines.

Purpose:

- The Federal Board of Revenue (FBR) claimed the proposal aimed to curb smuggling.

2. Criticisms of the Proposal

- **Failure to Address Smuggling:**

- Past similar regulations have failed to curtail the 'khepia' racket (informal smuggling networks).
- Smuggling thrives due to collusion between corrupt officials and smugglers.

- **Potential for Abuse:**

- The proposal gave arbitrary power to customs officials:
- Goods could be seized based on subjective assessments of their purpose or value.
- This risked harassment of ordinary travellers during luggage checks.

- **Inconvenience for Travellers:**

- Proposed rules were introduced at short notice before the winter holiday season, likely causing confusion and disruptions at airports.

3. Broader Implications

- **Ineffective Revenue Generation:**

- The measures did not aim to enhance revenue collection, raising doubts about their practicality.

Reputational Damage:

- Targeting incoming travellers gave an impression of misguided policy-making by the FBR.

Systemic Issues:

- The real issue lies with smuggling networks operating with the connivance of corrupt officials.

4. Recommendations for the FBR

- **Action Against Smuggling Networks:**

- The FBR should focus on targeting organized smuggling operations instead of inconveniencing ordinary citizens.

- **Address Internal Corruption:**

- Weed out corrupt actors within the administrative machinery who facilitate smuggling.

- **Transparent Policy-Making:**

- Proposals should be well-researched and avoid placing excessive power in the hands of individuals.
- **Minimize Passenger Harassment:**
 - Ensure that future measures do not lead to the unfair targeting of traveller.

Editorial(3):Grieving Elephants:

1. Death of Another Captive Elephant in Pakistan

- **Latest Tragedy:**
 - Sonia, an elephant at Karachi's Safari Park, passed away on Sunday.
 - Initial reports suggest sudden heart failure, with final confirmation pending autopsy results.

2. History of Elephant Deaths in Pakistan

- **Saheli (2012):**
 - Died in Islamabad Zoo due to injuries from being bound in chains.
- **Kaavan (2020):**
 - Known as the "world's loneliest elephant", Kaavan was relocated to a sanctuary in Cambodia after international outcry.
- **Suzi (2017):**
 - The only elephant at Lahore Zoo, she died due to neglect-related injuries.
- **Noor Jehan (2023):**
 - Passed away at Karachi Zoo after suffering from a protracted illness.
- **Madhubala and Sonia:**
 - Madhubala, Noor Jehan's sister, was moved to Karachi's Safari Park to reunite with Sonia and Malika.
- **Sonia's Death:** Sonia died less than two weeks after being reunited with Madhubala.

3. Elephants' Emotional Traits

- **Empathy and Mourning:**
 - Elephants are highly empathetic, capable of experiencing grief and mourning their dead.
 - Madhubala has now lost two companions in two years (Noor Jehan in 2023 and Sonia in 2024).
- **Human-like Traits:**
 - Elephants are loved and revered globally for their compassionate nature, even aiding other species in distress.

4. Poor Treatment of Elephants in Pakistan

- **Neglect and Lack of Care:**

- Common causes of death include injuries, neglect, and illness.
- Facilities like zoos have consistently failed to provide adequate care.

- **Lack of Empathy:**

- Pakistan's zoos lack the infrastructure and compassion needed to ensure elephants' well-being.

5. Recommendations

1. Sanctuary Relocation:

- Remaining elephants, like Madhubala and Malika, should be relocated to international sanctuaries similar to Kaavan.

2. Zoo Reforms:

- Pakistani zoos need overhauls to improve conditions for captive animals, including better medical care and living environments.

3. Public Awareness:

- Highlight elephants' emotional intelligence and encourage empathy to improve public pressure on authorities.

4. International Collaboration:

- Partner with global organizations to develop animal-friendly facilities and train zookeepers.

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